

Scroll Science

How feeds and notifications pull on you, and how to take the wheel



BIG IDEA Apps are built to hold attention, and heavy use can affect sleep, mood and friendships for some people. Research is still sorting out how much. When use is hard to stop or leaves you feeling worse, try a reset and talk to someone.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

REVIEW STATUS REQUIRES REVIEW BY A SCHOOL COUNSELOR OR CLINICIAN BEFORE CLASSROOM USE. Written 2026-10-05, not yet reviewed by anyone outside the author.

COUNSELOR HEADS-UP FIRST + OPT-OUT PLAN Counselor told 5 school days ahead (Appendix B); know your self-harm protocol and 988. Family note required. No formal opt-out, but one is honored (alternate: Lesson 10 My Limits plan). Teach mid-week.

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Hackles up? Notice how you feel after time on a screen: tired, restless, left out, or fine. That feeling is information, never a failure. “Ever picked up a phone for a minute and looked up half an hour later? Today is about why, and what we know. Some of what you hear online is solid, some is still being studied, and some is hype. Social media can be fun and useful, and for some people at some times it makes sleep, mood and friendships harder. We are noticing and choosing, with no blame.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *Solid, Still Studied, or Hype?*

- 1 (1 min) Read CF-P2.** Pia, twelve, scrolls in bed “for a few minutes.” Last night it was two hours. Pia is tired and keeps checking the phone, even in class. Pia is not lazy or weak: apps are built to be hard to put down.
- 2 (3 min) Evidence Cards.** Groups place six cards on SOLID, STILL STUDIED or HYPE. Debrief with reasons from the Answer Key. Only a doctor or counselor can tell whether use has become a health problem.
- 3 (2 min) Signals.** Lanes: TRY A RESET, TALK TO SOMEONE, GET HELP TODAY. Place four Signal Cards and name a helper. A character who feels hopeless or wants to hurt themselves always means tell an adult today.
- 4 (2 min) Reset Menu.** Circle two resets and add one trusted adult to the My Help Ladder card. Point to 988.

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “Which signal would you notice first? Which would be easiest to ignore?”
- 2** “Why can comparing yourself with others’ posts feel worse?”
- 3** “What can a friend say that helps without judging?” (“I noticed you seem tired. Want to take a break together?”)

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: RP2 Evidence Cards (six per group), Signal Cards and three-lane mat, Reset Menu per student, My Help Ladder card.

- ☐ Print the cards and mat per group; a Reset Menu per student.
- ☐ Ask no one about their own screen time or mood. Name no apps. Give no self-harm methods or suicide statistics.

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Pause when you notice a signal: tired, down, left out or stuck. Check what is pulling you, and try one reset. Tell a trusted adult if it keeps happening or you feel hopeless. It is never your fault.”

Hand signal: Hackles Up (hand brushed up the neck, optional), then Pause, Check, Tell. Post it: “You still get to choose, and you do not have to choose alone.”

EXIT TICKET “Write one reset you chose and one person who could help you stick to it.”

FUN BOOST Evidence Card Walk (calm; no scoring). Groups swap sorted cards, check silently whether they agree, then say one reason aloud.

LEVEL-UP Seven-Day Experiment. Try one reset for a week and note sleep and mood. Private.

DIFFERENTIATE Four Evidence Cards, three Signal Cards, sentence starters.

FAMILY CARD Ask: “What feels good about your apps, and what feels hard?” If your child seems very down, the counselor can help; 988 by call or text.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You are not in trouble, and it is not your fault.”
- “I’m glad you told me. You do not have to handle this alone.”
- “I can’t keep this secret. I need to bring in people who can help, and I will tell you who.”
- **Do not say:** “You are addicted.” Do not diagnose.
- “Just put the phone down.” “Everyone feels like that.”
- “I won’t tell anyone.”

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: any hint of self-harm or hopelessness: stay with the student, follow your district protocol, call or text 988. Tell your counselor or designated person the same day; follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.